

BRIEF 1 OF 3 — EDUCATION

Local Government and the Right to Education

Why municipal competences, not goodwill, determine whether inclusive schooling becomes real

Comparative evidence: Turin, Barcelona, Athens | Audience: city networks & municipal governments | June 2026

IN ONE SENTENCE

Where municipalities hold statutory planning and budgetary authority over schooling, as in Barcelona, inclusive education becomes an administrative routine; where they are confined to auxiliary functions, as in Athens, even the most resourceful local initiatives remain fragmented pilots dependent on EU cycles and NGO goodwill.

1. The Policy Problem

Across Southern Europe, municipalities sit at the school gate: they register newcomers, organise outreach for absentee children, and broker the everyday compromises that determine whether a constitutional promise of universal education becomes a lived experience. Yet the degree of authority granted to them for this task varies enormously, and that variation, rather than local political will, is what ultimately separates durable inclusion from improvised relief. A comparative reading of Turin, Barcelona, and Athens shows that municipal commitment to education is fairly constant across all three cities; what differs sharply is the institutional architecture that converts commitment into outcomes.

This brief distils the empirical findings of a comparative constitutional study of municipal social rights governance into operational guidance for city networks, national ministries negotiating decentralisation reforms, and EU bodies designing cohesion or education funding instruments.

2. What the Comparative Evidence Shows

All three cities examined embrace a broad conception of education that extends beyond compulsory schooling to early-childhood provision, adult learning, migrant language acquisition, and the link between education and civic belonging. This inclusive local vision is consistently more pragmatic and community-oriented than national curricular frameworks. The decisive variable, however, is institutional: whether that vision is backed by enforceable planning, operational, and budgetary powers.

City	Institutional capacity	Outcome pattern
Barcelona	Dedicated Education Consortium with integrated planning, operational, and budgetary powers, grounded in Catalonia's devolved competences.	Strongest equity and inclusion outcomes; anti-segregation programmes function as standing administrative tools rather than ad hoc projects.
Turin	Operates within a fragmented, regionalised Italian system; compensates through horizontal coordination, early-childhood investment, and participatory schemes (patti educativi di comunità).	Genuine local innovation, but uneven results that depend on sustained regional fiscal support and political continuity.
Athens	Confined to auxiliary functions — infrastructure upkeep and municipal nurseries — within a strongly centralised Greek system that recently reclaimed even adult-education competences.	Creative partnerships (Open Schools Programme, UNICEF, Stavros Niarchos Foundation projects) cannot anchor a coherent strategy; provision remains fragmented and chronically underfunded.

2.1 Coverage, accessibility, and inclusion

Coverage — the existence of school places and language support — diverges along the same institutional lines: Athens has scaled transitional classes for migrant children but struggles with geographical clustering; Turin integrates newcomers through neighbourhood schools with uneven results; Barcelona deploys broader anti-segregation programmes backed by regional competences. On accessibility, enrolment protocols and catchment rules make the practical difference between exclusion and entry: Turin's community-based outreach and Barcelona's regional support for school choice mitigate exclusion, whereas Athens depends heavily on NGOs to bridge access gaps that the municipality itself cannot close. Inclusion, finally, is where the architecture gap is most visible: Barcelona mainstreams equity through institutional tools embedded in everyday administration, while Athens' reliance on solidarity networks demonstrates resourcefulness but also exposes structural fragility, since access then depends on voluntary or project-based initiatives rather than durable public provision.

2.2 Beyond the school gate: lifelong learning

A recurring finding across all three cities is that municipal education policy is not confined to children. Libraries, vocational training, adult education, and community learning spaces extend the right to education across the life course, offering renewed opportunities to residents — including migrants and adults whose schooling was interrupted — for integration and civic participation. This dimension is frequently under-recognised in national education frameworks, which tend to define competences around compulsory schooling alone, leaving municipalities to fill the gap through their own initiative and budget lines.

3. Why Centralisation Does Not Equal Quality

Greece's recent re-centralisation of adult-education competences illustrates a broader pattern documented across this research: when national governments tighten control over policy areas with symbolic weight in nation-building, such as education, they often do so at the expense of the contextual responsiveness that only municipalities can provide. Centralisation promotes formal uniformity, but it does not, on its own, deliver equity. The Athens case demonstrates that constitutional silence on municipal education competences is not neutral; it actively constrains what local authorities — however motivated — can achieve, even when international partners are willing to co-fund pilot schemes.

4. Recommendations for City Networks and Policymakers

1. Clarify municipal education competences in primary legislation

- a) National and regional legislators should specify, rather than leave to discretion, which planning, enrolment, and budgetary functions belong to municipalities — particularly for early-childhood provision, migrant language support, and lifelong learning, where ambiguity currently invites both underfunding and recentralisation.

2. Shift from discretionary grants to multi-year, equalisation-based financing

- b) Project-based EU or philanthropic funding (as in Athens) demonstrates what municipalities can do but not what they can sustain. Education networks should advocate for multi-year funding instruments with equalisation floors so that inclusion measures outlast electoral and funding cycles.

3. Institutionalise co-production with civil society through standing frameworks

- c) Where NGOs and foundations currently substitute for absent state capacity, partnerships should be codified into multi-year frameworks defining standards, referral pathways, and accountability — converting co-production from a stopgap into a recognised pillar of public provision.

4. Treat city-to-city networks as capacity-building tools, not symbolic forums

- d) Eurocities and comparable networks add most value when they support concrete benchmarking and policy transfer — for example helping Athens-type municipalities adapt Barcelona's anti-segregation tools or Turin's community pacts — rather than functioning solely as advocacy platforms.

5. Invest in data infrastructure for lifelong learning

- e) Municipalities should be supported in building observatories that track enrolment, language acquisition, and adult-education uptake, enabling evidence-based adjustment and giving national governments a stronger basis for allocating competences and funding.

5. Closing Note

Local autonomy in education is not an administrative convenience; the comparative evidence indicates it is a structural condition for translating a universal right into a lived reality. Municipal commitment to inclusive education is, on this evidence, widely shared across very different national contexts. What is unevenly distributed — and what policy reform should therefore target — is the institutional capacity to act on that commitment.